

seats at the 'Lowest Available' fares, and each seat cost us Rs 17,180.

[B] Cost of travel (Jet Airways):

Rs 17,180 x 2 = Rs 34,360

Grand Total (A+B):

Rs 48,178 (\$1,025 approx)

The Online Travel Planners

Planning an entire holiday using one of the two major portals available—TravelJini.com and MakeMyTrip.com—can sure make life easier.

TravelJini.com, for example, also houses surrogate travel agents White Mischief and Black Mischief who offer adventure, romance, 'friends' and 'high spirits' holidays! These trips are planned to the last detail and offer destinations including Bangalore-Mysore-Ooty-Coimbatore and Goa and even a Himalayan Jeep Safari. The Safari, for example, includes an open jeep journey throughout with stops in Manali and Khajjar, touted as "India's Switzerland"!

Other seasonal holidays even included a 'Ganeshotsav' package near Panvel in Maharashtra and a contest where you could win a holiday in Goa. International holidays here include destinations in Austria in particular and the rest of Europe in general.

To be honest, the list of destinations offered here is so extensive that we cannot possibly include it. Suffice to say, though, that any place you are planning from Ladakh to Kerala to visit is on their list.

But its not only domestic holidays that one can book using these portals. Even international destinations are available and TravelJini.com has a fairly exhaustive list of these as well. MakeMyTrip.com it seems is focussing more on the foreign trips with the homepage advertising mostly these while the Indian holidays are spread across the page with a special link on the top.

But a click on the 'Holidays' link on the homepage will lead you to a very nice search tool that will update destination options based on initial choices of regions. So if you choose 'North India', a list of destinations from this area will be available in the next list. Clicking on the required



MakeMyTrip.com is perhaps the only complete portal that lets you pay and complete all formalities online



Online booking is almost a given with all domestic airlines, including the newer ones such as SpiceJet

options will bring up all packages available in that area for your choice of dates.

One of the main advantages of searching and booking using such a portal is that when choosing your destinations itself, you are offered all necessary information on the destination that you can read up on before deciding. Notably, MakeMyTrip.com is a global portal and also has the option of paying in US dollars.

In the case of TravelJini.com, the domestic travel options are mind-boggling and you could well find yourself confused about where you would want to go! It's almost an embarrassment of riches.

For actually booking your holiday with either portal, a free registration is required. This information is used for your contact details and so on so the next time you book a journey with them, you don't have to fill in these details again.

A noteworthy addition here is the 'Create an alert' one that lets you create an alert for airfares between two chosen destinations. This way, you are kept aware of the lowest fares for that journey from time to time. It's also worth keeping an eye on this site if you fly frequently for they claim to have the lowest airfare available.

Payment options are not too large and paying on MakeMyTrip.com is through major credit cards. TravelJini.com, though, will tell you your fare and other expense details and "Get back to you shortly"!

Au Revoir

Almost none of the travel agents (barring two) offers online payment options, all the airlines are offering this option making it that much easier to plan a journey but not a holiday.

One thing that one does miss out on here is the option of planning a customised trip. You are better off doing that by yourself especially if you want a trekking or hiking trip.

Also, unlike in the US, in India, renting a car for an adventure journey of your own is not all that easy. You will probably be better off landing up at your destination and then booking a vehicle for local transport. ☒

aditya_kuber@thinkdigit.com